

with the rest of your team over a shared Web calendar—instead of booting your sizeable laptop.

It is always easier to update your PDA-phone while on the go and then sync it later with your PC later at night. Similarly, reminders about meetings or birthdays, and checking e-mail while travelling, are tasks for which PDA-phones are more practical than laptops.

On-the-road practicality is what prompted Santosh Savant to opt for a PDA-phone over a laptop. As the brand manager of Cosmos Brands International Pvt Ltd, Savant relies on his Nokia Communicator 9210i for “scheduling meetings and anniversary reminders.” As he puts it, “While travelling, the size and weight of the device really matters; a laptop weighs over a kilogram, and the 250 grams of a PDA-phone is a significant reduction... the PDA-phone notifies me about events instantly. The same can’t be said about laptops for the simple reason that they won’t be switched on all the time.”

We are, of course, not suggesting that the laptop is replaceable by the phone—not yet at least. The two complement each other well—a phone to gather and check upon data quickly, a laptop to work upon collated data at a less hectic time and locale. As Santosh Savant, brand manager, Cosmos International Brands Pvt Ltd, agrees, “...a laptop is a better bet if you do lot of presentations, work with sheets, etc, but for e-mail on the go, a PDA is as good as a laptop.”

Mobile e-mail has become very important in the business world. A 2004 survey by research firm InStat/MDR highlighted that the biggest concern to mobile business users is staying connected to customers, co-workers, and critical data. The survey went on to note that for their cell phones, users want basic functionalities such as speaker-phones and e-mail capabilities. This fact has been underlined by the industry itself—BlackBerry devices are finding favour with users for their e-mail capabilities and their ability to tie seamlessly with Microsoft Exchange servers. Indeed, their success has prompted PalmSource to carve

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out a deal with Microsoft to be able to communicate with Exchange servers... Microsoft, in turn, is looking to add support for so-called ‘auxiliary display devices’ to their upcoming—any time now—Longhorn OS.

Microsoft wants PC makers to mount cell phone-like displays on the lids of laptop computers so that users can check the time, battery status and appointments, or see if new e-mail has arrived without having to start up their portable PCs. Such functionality is already planned for ‘handtops’ such as the upcoming FlipStart (www.flipstartpc.com).

Will the future bring in the so-called ‘road warriors’—men and women connected digitally to offices yet not tethered physically to a geographical location?

A look at present devices certainly points to such a scenario. When we tested devices for this article, convergence and portability featured prominently across laptops and PDA-phones. So let’s take a look at what the market is offering. As mentioned, we have divided this article into laptops and PDA-phones. We begin with the laptops.

LAPTOPS

Based on its form, a laptop can either be an ‘ultra-portable’—small and light—or a workhorse—big and feature-rich. One of the common elements threading through these disparate devices is battery life. Although it is an important element in the usability of portable electronics, battery life, at present, doesn’t satisfy. Hovering around the three-hour mark, you would be remiss not to carry an extra battery pack along. Perhaps with the introduction of less hungry processors, better batteries, and someday, of OLED screens, this facet will improve.

As of today, large screens, optical drives, fast hard disks, wireless connectivity, all conspire to hold battery life down—the best a laptop could do under our admittedly gruelling

battery test was make it past four hours (it was an Acer TravelMate, in case you are wondering). Our recommendation is that you seriously consider investing in an extra



Fujitsu LifeBook S7010

and a smartphone from a PDA. If you are looking at a communication device that offers rudimentary contact management and call management, then almost any cell phone in the market would be it. But we went a little further here.

With an eye on data manipulation and data portability, we argued that an ideal device would be a ‘PDA phone’: more PDA than phone, with a good, viewable screen, data input via either a keyboard or handwriting recognition software, and finally, with the ability to make phone calls. Such a device is ideal when called for noting down someone’s contact (or for exchanging contact information wirelessly after a meeting or presentation); to create to-do lists; or for synching your calendar